FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

Access Changes Implemented to Protect Local Watershed

Ladysmith, BC — The Town of Ladysmith, the Province and Forestry Stakeholders are advising the public of new access controls on the Banon Creek Forest Service Road to help protect drinking water, forest resources, and public safety.

Due to ongoing issues with unauthorized camping and illegal dumping resulting in an increased wildfire risk and possible watershed contamination, weekday access to the area will be restricted.

Beginning on May 19, 2026, the access gate to the Banon Creek Forest Service Road at the end of South Watts Road will be closed Monday to Friday. It will be open on weekends and statutory holidays from 8:00 am to 4:00 pm.

“We know the gate closure is disappointing for many community members who use the area for recreation, especially during the warmer months. Unfortunately, weekday closures are necessary due to the increased risk of wildfire,” says Nicholas Pescod, the Town’s Communications & Engagement Specialist.

Environment and Climate Change Canada is predicting 2026 to be one of the hottest summers on record. A major wildfire within the watershed could significantly deplete the Town’s reservoir, impact water quality, and require severe water restrictions. These measures are intended to reduce risk while still allowing for responsible recreational use.

The watershed is located outside Town boundaries and is managed under provincial timber licences held by private forestry companies and Indigenous forestry operators. The Town owns the Holland Lake reservoir and jointly owns the Stocking Lake reservoir and surrounding lands with the CVRD. Access and watershed projection agreements are in place with adjacent landowners. As such, the Town does not directly control access to the watershed but is working collaboratively with the Ministry of Forests and land managers to better regulate use of the area.

This watershed provides drinking water for approximately 12,000 people in the areas of the Town of Ladysmith, the Stz’uminus First Nation, the Diamond and Saltair.

Recreational access will continue on weekends and statutory holidays. Non-motorized users can access the watershed at any time and the Stocking Lake, Heart Lake and Banon Creek Falls trails will remain open for non-motorized use. Non-motorized users wishing to reach Banon Creek Falls from Monday to Friday can use the Stocking Lake trail to reach the Banon Creek Service Road, then head south to the spur road that provides access to the trailhead.

Updated access information and maps will be shared through social media, direct notifications, and online resources.

The Town and the Province will continue to monitor activity in the area and will attempt to balance recreational access with watershed protection.

LINK TO MAP PDF HERE
LINK TO GPS DATA HERE

The Town of Ladysmith respectfully acknowledges that we gather and work on the unceded territory of the Stz'uminus First Nation, the traditional keepers of this land.

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